

The Quiet Cubicle I Miss Against My Will

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Essay

July 4, 2026

A summer vacation survival essay for every parent who has ever muted a meeting to adjudicate a fight about absolutely nothing.

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At 9:17 on a Tuesday morning, I heard what sounded like a raccoon being folded into a card table.

This is not, technically speaking, a normal sound to hear during a workday. It is especially not normal when you are on a call with actual adults, trying to discuss actual work, while silently praying that whatever is happening upstairs does not involve blood, broken glass, or the kind of sibling injury that requires an ice pack.

Then came the scream.

Not a fear scream. Not a pain scream. A sibling scream. Parents know the difference. A pain scream makes your body move before your brain catches up. A sibling scream makes your soul leave your body, circle the room once, and say, “Really? This again?”

I muted myself, because the mute button has become the modern work-from-home parent’s confessional booth, panic room, and emotional support animal. I climbed upstairs and found two of my boys locked in a dispute of such legal and moral complexity that it apparently required immediate arbitration from a man currently being paid by an employer to do something other than explain whose turn it was watch their cartoon.

A cartoon.

Not a car. Not inheritance rights. Not the future control of a small European country.

A cartoon.

One of them looked at me with the righteous fury of a man wronged before a hostile court and said, “He won’t let me play with him.”

The other one, surrounded by cracker crumbs and the haunted remains of what used to be a clean kitchen, said, “Can I have a cookie?”

And that, right there, is the work-from-home experience.

My wife and I both work from home. I have been doing it for almost 15 years now, which means I was working remotely before half the country discovered Zoom, athleisure, and the spiritual danger of never leaving your house. I have worked through meetings, deadlines, sick days, school closings, snow days, summer vacations, internet outages, and the occasional mysterious household crash that everyone denies causing, even though the dog lacks both thumbs and motive.

I love working from home.

Let me be clear before anyone imagines me polishing a résumé for a return to fluorescent lights and conference room coffee that tastes like somebody rinsed a tire in hot water. Working from home has been a gift. It has given me time with my family, flexibility, fewer commutes, and the ability to eat lunch without pretending a sad desk salad is a lifestyle choice.

When the kids are in school, it is glorious.

The house is quiet. The coffee is still hot. My office is my office. I can think complete thoughts. I can have a meeting without a child appearing behind me like a poorly timed ghost from a Victorian novel. I can finish a

sentence without someone asking where the tape is, why the Wi-Fi is slow, whether we have more cereal, or whether “technically” hitting your brother with a pillow counts if the pillow was “already moving.”

But then summer arrives.

Summer vacation for kids is freedom, sunshine, snacks, sleeping in, and the slow destruction of every household routine known to civilization. Summer vacation for work-from-home parents is a hostage negotiation with better weather.

There are days, and I am not proud of this, when I long for a quiet cubicle.

That sentence should be enough to trigger a national conversation. Nobody should long for a cubicle. Cubicles were invented by people who looked at human creativity and said, “What if we trapped it in beige fabric under humming lights?” And yet there I am, in true Rob fashion, sitting in my home office, surrounded by the life I supposedly wanted, thinking wistfully about a gray little work pen where nobody would barge in to ask whether Pop-Tarts count as lunch.

This is where things are at.

The hardest part is that my kids do not seem to understand the concept of work from home. Not “they forget sometimes.” Not “they struggle with it because they’re young.” I mean the entire category appears to be missing from their mental filing cabinet. Work, to them, is apparently something that happens somewhere else, in an office building, with a badge and a parking lot and maybe a vending machine. Home is home. Home means Dad is available. Mom is available. Doors are decorative. Headphones are ceremonial. A calendar invite is just a suggestion made by strangers.

And to be fair, I can see how this might confuse a kid.

For most of human history, if your parent was in the house, your parent was, at least in theory, available. Maybe tired. Maybe crabby. Maybe holding a laundry basket and muttering dark things about people who turn socks inside out and throw them behind the couch. But present. Home meant family life. Work meant leaving.

Then along came technology, and now we have this strange little arrangement where the adult body is physically in the house, but the adult mind is inside a spreadsheet, a Teams call, a contract, a customer issue, a budget review, or some other joyless digital cave where hope goes to update permissions.

Children see the body.

They do not respect the spreadsheet.

I get it. I really do. When I was a kid in the 80s and 90s, work had geography. Adults went to work. They drove there. They wore different clothes. They came home at a certain time, carrying a lunch box, briefcase, tool bag, or the defeated posture of someone who had spent all day pretending a copier jam was not going to break them. There was a line between work and home. Not a perfect line, for sure, but a visible one.

Now the line is invisible.

It runs somewhere between the office door and the pantry, between a meeting and a Nerf dart, between professional responsibility and a child standing three feet away whisper-yelling, “Dad. Dad. Dad. Dad. Dad. Dad.”

I have tried to explain it.

We have had calm family meetings. We have had stern talks. We have had “unless the house is on fire, bleeding, or someone is actively being kidnapped by raccoons, do not interrupt” policies. We have discussed work hours. We have discussed boundaries. We have discussed the fact that Mom and Dad are not sitting in these rooms for personal enrichment, listening to adults talk about action items because we find it emotionally nourishing.

And yet, five minutes later, someone opens the door and asks if they can have a cookie.

The cookie question is special because it contains, within it, the entire collapse of civilization.

Can you have a cookie? I don’t know. What time is it? Have you eaten real food? Why are you asking me and not using any of the judgment we have allegedly spent years trying to install in you? Why did this question require you to interrupt a meeting? Why are you making direct eye contact with me while I am clearly wearing headphones and speaking in my work voice? Why are there already cookie crumbs on your shirt if this decision has not yet been authorized?

It is not really about the cookie.

It is about the assumption that every adult function in the house can be paused because a child has encountered a feeling, a craving, a boredom, an injustice, or a brother.

Especially a brother.

My boys, when left without a parental eye on them during the workday, raid the kitchen like they have been starved in a POW camp. I mean this with the full love of a father and the full suspicion of a man who contributes to the grocery bill. They move through the pantry like locusts with youth soccer schedules. Boxes are opened. Bags are left unsealed. Evidence is abandoned in plain sight because criminals, apparently, no longer value craftsmanship.

They eat like we have been feeding them nothing but ice chips and inspirational quotes.

Then, fueled by tortilla chips, fruit snacks, and whatever emotional instability comes from eating three granola bars in twelve minutes, they begin arguing over the stupidest things imaginable. Who breathed near whom. Who looked at whose screen. Who sat in the good chair. Who made a noise. Who copied a noise. Who copied the accusation of copying a noise. These are not arguments. These are congressional hearings conducted by raccoons.

And because the adults are home, the adults must judge.

Never mind that the adults are working. Never mind that the mortgage exists. Never mind that the same children have lived through layoffs and long-term unemployment in this house and have seen, up close, what happens when work goes away. That part is what really gets me.

Because this is not just about noise.

If it were only noise, I could buy better headphones. I could soundproof the door. I could move to the garage attic and work beside the Christmas decorations and one suspicious box labeled “miscellaneous,” which is just Latin for “we gave up.”

The deeper frustration is that work is treated as optional because it is happening at home.

My wife and I have both carried the stress of work and the stress of losing work. Our kids have seen the tension. They have seen the budget talks, the job searching, the worry behind closed doors that were not quite closed enough. They have seen the difference between steady employment and long-term uncertainty. They may not understand all of it, and honestly I hope they don't. Kids should not have to carry adult fear. But they are old enough, ranging from 18 to 10, to understand that work matters.

They are old enough to understand that a closed office door is not a challenge.

They are old enough to understand that parents are people with obligations.

They are old enough to understand that a paycheck does not magically emerge from the Wi-Fi router because Dad wore sweatpants and stayed upstairs.

And yet here we are.

This is where the humor starts to crack a little, because under the absurdity is something that bothers me in a more serious way. I do not need my kids to worship work. I am not trying to raise tiny corporate monks who bow toward LinkedIn at sunrise. I do not want them to think a job is the whole measure of a person. I have seen enough of life to know better than that.

But I do want them to respect effort.

I want them to understand that other people's time matters. That concentration matters. That interruption has a cost. That a home can be loving and still have rules. That being physically near someone does not mean you are entitled to every piece of their attention whenever your boredom gets loud.

That is not just a work-from-home lesson. That is a human lesson.

Right now, we live in a culture that has become very good at access and very bad at boundaries. Everything is immediate. Texts, notifications, deliveries, entertainment, answers, opinions, outrage, snacks. Especially snacks. We can summon almost anything with a few taps, and somehow that convenience has trained us to think wanting something is the same as needing it.

Kids are not immune to that. Of course they aren't. They are growing up in a world where every screen says, "Here, now, instantly, for you." Then they walk past my wife's office and see her sitting there, physically present, and the logic kicks in.

Mom is here.

I have a need.

The need is cookie-shaped.

Therefore, Mom.

There is a kind of brutal efficiency to it.

But family life cannot work that way. Work cannot work that way. Marriage cannot work that way. Society cannot work that way, though it seems determined to run the experiment until we all collapse into notifications and empty Goldfish bags.

At the end of the day, I want my kids to know that work from home is still work. It is not pretend work. It is not half-work. It is not “Dad is sort of busy but probably available if I apply enough pressure.” It is work. The location changed. The obligation did not.

And I want them to know something else too.

The reason my wife and I fight so hard to keep working, to stay employed, to show up, to push through interruptions and chaos and summer vacation madness, is not because we love meetings. We do not. Nobody loves meetings. Meetings are what happen when emails get ambitious.

We do it because we are trying to hold the roof up.

We are trying to provide stability. We are trying to keep the bills paid, the groceries coming, the school stuff handled, the shoes replaced, the sports fees covered, the internet on, the future somewhat less terrifying than it might otherwise be. Most days, we do that imperfectly. Some days, we do it while yelling, “I AM ON A CALL” through a closed door in a tone that probably does not appear in parenting books.

Oh well.

The older I get, the more I realize kids learn respect slowly, and usually by colliding with the lack of it in themselves. They do not wake up one morning magically understanding adult pressure. They learn it through repetition, consequences, reminders, frustration, apology, and watching us try again. Which is annoying, because I would prefer a software update.

But children are not apps. They are people. Loud people. Hungry people. People who somehow believe “quiet” means “make the same noise, but with more whisper.” People who need to be taught, again and again, that love is not the same thing as unlimited access.

So we keep teaching it.

We keep closing the door. We keep explaining. We keep saying no to cookies at 9:17 in the morning. We keep telling them to solve the TV dispute without federal intervention. We keep reminding them that Mom and Dad are working, even if we are in the house, even if the car is in the driveway, even if the office is only fourteen stairs from the living room.

And some days we fail. Some days they barge in. Some days I lose patience. Some days I miss the quiet cubicle, which remains one of the saddest sentences I have ever written.

But maybe that is the work too.

Not just the paid work. The other work. The work of teaching people you love how to live with other people. The work of helping kids understand that the world does not stop every time they want a cookie, that other people have duties, that respect is not reserved for offices with badges and parking lots.

Home is where the family is.

It is also where the work is.

And everybody in the house needs to learn that.